becoming a desert is India's North-East Monsoon, when the south-westerly winds turn about in the autumn and start blowing from the north-east. These winds pick up moisture as they cross the Bay of Bengal, some of which falls on the eastern flanks of the southern section of the Western Ghats. This rainfall drains into a series of extended river systems that follow the gentle slope of the land all the way across the peninsula to empty into the Bay of Bengal.

Once the first hominids and the modern humans who followed them had rounded the tip of the Indian peninsula these rivers gave them access to the interior – most obviously the Godavari and the Krishna, which constitute two of the four largest rivers in India in terms of water inflow, each with numerous tributaries. In the case of the Krishna, one of its longest tributaries is the Tungabhadra, which joins it just west of Kurnool in the very centre of the Indian peninsula. Here the Tungabhadra forms the northern boundary of the Bellary District (now Ballari in Karnataka). In 1872 the geologist Robert Foote was contacted by the engineer in charge of public works in Bellary who wanted him to take a look at a ridge just to the north-east of Bellary town known locally in the Kannada language as Hiregudda ('big hill').

A prominent peak on the ridge, known from its shape as Kappagallu, or 'Peacock Hill', was found by Foote to be strewn with worked stone tools 'in all the several states from the roughest beginning to the most polished and highly finished axe, adze or chisel'. So busy was Foote exploring what he afterwards described as 'this celt factory' that he had no time to fully explore Peacock Hill and, in particular, its northern slopes. However, following reports of 'very interesting graffiti' on that side of the hill Foote returned to Bellary in 1903 to find the vertical surfaces of its larger rocks covered in what he termed 'rock-bruisings' but now known as petroglyphs – images hammered or picked into rock surfaces – many showing long-horned, hump-backed